leadership hit home. Failure, on that scale, is an extremely public process. Press conferences were brutal, though I sensed a degree of respect because when the story is that big the captain is only one of many characters to consider.

Everyone had a view. Opinions were being formed on little or no knowledge. I understood the process, accepted that cricket was part of the national conversation and promised myself never to react impulsively. Some of the second-hand stuff I heard or read was nonsense, but I ignored it. All I could do was act on one of international sport's truisms and attempt to control the controllables.

Paul Downton arrived in Australia to evaluate the mood, and consult those closest to the issues, prior to taking up the role of the ECB's managing director on 1 February 2014. I spent a couple of hours with Ashley Giles, coach of the one-day side, in his room, trying to rationalize what the future looked like.

Andy's time as Test team director was clearly coming to an end. He'd had enough. It was an obvious opportunity to reassess and rebuild. I still wanted to lead and was told I retained the confidence of my employers. There were signs of promise, in Ben Stokes and Joe Root, but discussions kept returning to the thorniest issue: what should we do about Kevin?

KP had returned home after the Ashes series. I spoke separately to Downton and Giles Clarke, the ECB chairman. Giles has a polarizing personality, but I found him intelligent and impressive, especially in board meetings. I realized the gravity of some of the conversations, and wanted to give a balanced view, without excessive emotion.

Should I have shared my thoughts, in depth, with KP as part of that process? Probably so, though the atmosphere was not conducive to mutual trust. He was publicly bullish about his desire to help us regain the Ashes in 2015, but my sense, over the previous twelve months, was that his ambition had waned. I thought he'd had his fill of playing for England.

As a captain, I had to cut through the noise and glitter of the KP brand and analyse his impact on those around him. Managing him on a day-to-day basis was fine. Small issues, such as his expectation that he would occasionally be given special dispensation, were dealt with relatively smoothly, though prone to potential complication.

Kevin, an imposing figure, had a major impact on the dressing room. If he didn't particularly care about something, or if, conversely, he had